

Euthanasia

prc-euthanasia

Christian Ethics · End of Life · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.963
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Active euthanasia and assisted suicide are wrong; allowing natural death and refusing futile treatment is permitted.

In plain language

The first part of this proposition has dense, repeated word-level support. Exodus 20:13 places the absolute negative lo in front of the verb ratsach, giving the command you shall not murder. Across its forty-six appearances, ratsach is the technical term for the unlawful killing of a human person, used in the cities-of-refuge laws to mark both the manslayer and the murderer, and kept separate from judicial execution and warfare. Genesis 9:6 grounds the ban in the image of God, tselem, with blood, dam, used twice, so the wrongness of taking innocent human life is tied to the victim's image-bearing status rather than to the victim's strength or condition. The clearest narrative test case in Scripture is 2 Samuel 1. An Amalekite reports that he found Saul mortally wounded, that Saul knew he would not live, chayah, and that at Saul's own request he put him to death, muth, the same verb pair the Bible elsewhere reserves for God. David then places the blood, dam, on the Amalekite's own head and has him executed. The canon's closest lexical analogue to assisted dying therefore counts against active mercy-killing, even at the sufferer's reported request. Deuteronomy 32:39 and 1 Samuel 2:6 use the same pair, muth and chayah, to declare that God alone puts to death and makes alive, with no one able to rescue from his hand. Job 1:21 adds that the LORD gives, natan, and takes away, laqach, and is to be blessed in both. These texts place the timing of death under God's authority and rule out a creature seizing that timing. What the canon does not supply is a separate word distinguishing the withholding of futile treatment from killing, so the second half of the proposition, that letting a natural death happen is permitted, is a coherent inference from the sovereignty texts and the narrow meaning of ratsach rather than a directly stated rule. Compassion for the suffering is a real biblical category, but in the canonical vocabulary it always terminates in care, presence, and healing, never in ending the sufferer's life. Confidence is set at medium because the prohibition half is decisive while the permission half is inferred.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H1288	בָּרַךְ	barak	to bless	305
H1818	דָּם	dam	blood	360
H2421	חַיָּה	chayah	to live	270
H3808	לֹא	lo	not	4,825
H3947	לָקַח	laqach	to take	967
H4191	מוֹת	muth	to die	807
H4899	מָשַׁח	mashiach	anointed	39
H5337	נָצַל	natsal	to rescue	181

H5414	נָתַן	natan	to give	2,014
H6754	צֶלֶם	tselem	image	17
H7495	רָפָא	rapha	to heal	62
H7523	רָצַח	ratsach	to murder	46
H7843	שָׁחַת	shachat	to ruin	152

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The prohibition clause rests on a dense, pan-canonical lexical chain. Exod 20:13 fixes H3808 lo with the Qal imperfect of H7523 ratsach as an absolute ban on wrongful killing of a person. Gen 9:6 grounds that ban in H6754 tselem, the image of God, paired with H1818 dam, blood. The narrative test case in 2 Sam 1:10, 14-16 directly lexicalizes a mercy-killing scenario: the Amalekite reports that Saul asked him to finish him because he would not H2421 chayah, live, so he H4191 muth, put him to death; David then condemns and executes him, naming the act shedding of H1818 dam, blood. The divine-prerogative formula H4191 muth Hiphil set against H2421 chayah Piel recurs in Deut 32:39 and 1 Sam 2:6, locating life and death under God's hand. Job 1:21 (H5414 natan, H3947 laqach) joins the same chain. The second clause, that refusing futile treatment and permitting natural death is allowed, is a coherent inference from the sovereignty texts and the narrow scope of ratsach, but the canon supplies no discrete term distinguishing withdrawal of futile care from active killing, which is the source of the residual uncertainty.

Scripture

Exod.20.13 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7523 רָצַח, H3808 לֹא

Force. The clause lo tirtsach joins the absolute negative H3808 with the Qal imperfect of H7523 ratsach to express a permanent prohibition. Across the 46 canonical occurrences of ratsach, including the cities-of-refuge legislation in Num 35 where it is the technical verb for the manslayer and murderer, the term denotes the killing of a human person and is set apart from judicial execution and warfare. The intent-and-act of active euthanasia and assisted suicide both fall inside that scope, so the commandment reaches them directly.

Gen.9.6 · for · genre: narrative · figures: chiasm

Key terms. H1818 דָּם; H6754 צֶלֶם

Force. The Noahic charter twice uses H1818 dam, blood, and grounds the sanction in H6754 tselem, image, of God. The clause shapes blood for blood as a chiastic warning, then anchors the ban in the image-bearing status of the victim, not in the victim's condition or consent. This makes the wrongness of taking innocent human life a property of the bearer of the image, which sickness and suffering do not erase, so a mercy motive does not remove the act from the verse's scope.

2Sam.1.10 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H4191 מוֹת, H2421 חַיָּה

Force. The Amalekite narrates a textbook mercy-killing: he stood over Saul and H4191 muth, put him to death, because he knew Saul would not H2421 chayah, live, after his fall. The verbs are the same pair that elsewhere belongs to God in Deut 32:39 and 1 Sam 2:6, and the report frames the act as compassion at the sufferer's own request.

2Sam.1.16 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H1818 דם, H4191 מות, H4899 משיח

Force. David places H1818 dam, blood, on the Amalekite's own head and has him H4191 muth, put to death, citing his confession that he stretched out his hand against the H4899 mashiach. The narrative condemns the killer even on the reported request of the sufferer, which is the closest lexical analogue to assisted dying the canon offers and which renders the request irrelevant to the verdict on the act.

Job.1.21 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5414 נתן, H3947 לקח, H1288 בָּרַךְ

Force. Job confesses that YHWH H5414 natan, gives, and YHWH H3947 laqach, takes away, then pronounces the divine name H1288 barak, blessed. The balanced give-and-take clauses assign the disposal of life and possessions, including the timing of death, to God rather than to the sufferer or to a third party acting on the sufferer's behalf. This locates the end of life within divine prerogative, which is consistent with declining to seize that prerogative by active killing.

Deut.32.39 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: merism

Key terms. H4191 מות, H2421 תִּיָּה, H5337 נָצַל, H7495 רָפָא

Force. The self-declaration sets the Hiphil H4191 muth, I put to death, against the Piel H2421 chayah, I make alive, and the Qal H7495 rapha, I heal, asserting that no one is a H5337 natsal, deliverer, from God's hand. The pairing of killing and making alive is a merism for total sovereignty over life-span. This grounds the prohibition on a creature usurping that authority through deliberate killing, while the same sovereignty over natural lifespan is coherent with allowing death to run its course when treatment cannot heal.

1Sam.2.6 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: merism

Key terms. H4191 מות, H2421 תִּיָּה

Force. Hannah's song mirrors the Deut 32:39 formula: YHWH H4191 muth, kills, and H2421 chayah, makes alive. The pairing recurs as a stock confession of divine prerogative over life and death, confirming that the merism is a pan-canonical pattern and not a one-off in the song of Moses.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Exod.20.13	Gen.9.6	tsk	1
Exod.20.13	Exod.21.14	tsk	1
Exod.20.13	Num.35.16	tsk	1
Deut.32.39	1Sam.2.6	tsk	1
Deut.32.39	Job.10.7	tsk	1
Deut.32.39	Isa.41.4	tsk	1
Deut.32.39	Deut.4.35	tsk	1
Job.1.21	Gen.3.19	tsk	1
Job.1.21	Gen.45.5	tsk	1
Job.1.21	Job.1.11	tsk	1
Job.1.21	Job.2.10	tsk	1
2Sam.1.16	1Kgs.2.32	tsk	1

Complicating texts

2Sam.1.10 · addressed

The Amalekite frames his act as compassion at Saul's reported request, which is the rhetorical case for mercy-killing in canonical form. The narrative resolves it in 2 Sam 1:14-16 by condemning the killer and placing the dam, blood, on his own head, so the verb pair muth and chayah used on a creaturely actor at a sufferer's request is treated as blood-guilt and not as mercy. The closest lexical analogue to assisted dying the canon provides therefore counts against active mercy-killing rather than for it.

Exod.21.14 · addressed

The statute removes a presumptuous killer from the altar for death, showing that the canon distinguishes culpable killing from sanctioned judicial action. This confirms that H7523 ratsach targets unlawful killing specifically, which is the category active euthanasia occupies, and does not weaken the prohibition.

Mark.5.19 · addressed

The Greek instruction to report what the Lord has done is part of the canonical pattern of compassion for the suffering, but it commands proclamation, not life-taking. Compassion as a lexical category in both testaments terminates in healing, comfort, mercy, and presence, never in administering death, so it does not authorize a mercy-killing exception to the prohibition on ratsach.

Deut.32.39 · unaddressed

The second clause of the proposition, that refusing futile treatment and permitting natural death is allowed, is not directly lexicalized in any anchor verse. The texts establish divine sovereignty over the timing of death and condemn the creaturely seizure of that timing, but the canon supplies no discrete Hebrew or Greek term distinguishing the withholding of extraordinary or futile means from active killing. The permission therefore remains a coherent inference from the sovereignty texts and the narrow semantic scope of ratsach rather than a directly attested lexical rule, and it is left unresolved at the lexical level.

Concordance traversed

H7523, H3808, H1818, H6754, H4191, H2421, H5337, H7495, H5414, H3947, H1288, H7843, H4899

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

All anchors and added witnesses are Old Testament Hebrew texts outside the ECM (CBGM) scope. The bundle reports not_in_ecm_scope true and supplies no variant units. The Masoretic readings of Exod 20:13, Gen 9:6, 2 Sam 1:10 and 14-16, Job 1:21, Deut 32:39, and 1 Sam 2:6 are stable in the Hebrew tradition and carry no verdict-affecting textual variation.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. sanctity-of-life-from-imago-dei, compassion-for-the-suffering, active-versus-passive-distinction

analogia scripturae invoked

grammatico-historical reading of the murder prohibition: affirms the prohibition clause directly · The fixed pairing of H3808 lo with H7523 ratsach in Exod 20:13, set in the Num 35 refuge-city legislation where the verb is the technical term for unlawful killing of a person, places intentional administration of death inside the prohibited zone regardless of the actor's motive.

sanctity-of-life from imago dei: affirms the prohibition clause · Gen 9:6 grounds the ban on shedding human H1818 dam, blood, in the victim's status as H6754 tselem, image of God. The image-bearing status is intrinsic and not voided by suffering, so the lexical case for sanctity does not contain a mercy exception.

divine prerogative over life and death: affirms the prohibition clause and grounds the inferred permission · The recurring merism H4191 muth and H2421 chayah in Deut 32:39 and 1 Sam 2:6, together with H5414 natan and H3947 laqach in Job 1:21, assigns the timing of death to God. A creature usurping that timing by active killing is

foreclosed, while a creature declining to oppose that timing by indefinitely forcing life is coherent with the same texts.

compassion-for-the-suffering lens: real but does not authorize active life-taking · The canonical vocabulary of compassion, mercy, comfort, and healing (including H7495 rapha and the Greek splanchnizomai family in the gospels) terminates in care, presence, and restoration. No lexical term in either testament licenses ending the sufferer's life as a means of relieving suffering, and the one narrative case shaped as compassion-killing in 2 Sam 1 is condemned.

active-versus-passive distinction: supports the permission clause as an inference, not as a direct lexical rule · The canon supplies no single Hebrew or Greek term distinguishing the deliberate killing covered by ratsach from the withholding of extraordinary means in a dying person. The distinction is coherent with the divine-prerogative texts but is reached by analogy and the narrow scope of the prohibition verb, which is the source of residual uncertainty on the permission half.

The prohibition half of the proposition is lexically dense and pan-canonical: the H7523 ratsach prohibition, the H1818 dam plus H6754 tselem ground in Gen 9:6, the H4191 muth and H2421 chayah merism for divine prerogative in Deut 32:39 and 1 Sam 2:6, and the 2 Sam 1 narrative test case all converge. The permission half, allowing natural death and refusing futile treatment, is reached by analogy from the divine-prerogative texts and the narrow scope of ratsach, not by a dedicated lexical term, so it is an inference rather than a lexicalized rule.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What does the canon say about intentionally causing the death of a suffering person, about assisting another to end their own life, and about withholding or withdrawing treatment when death is otherwise imminent?

The original stem bundles a moral judgment, that active euthanasia and assisted suicide are wrong, with a permission, that allowing natural death and refusing futile treatment is acceptable. The wrong and permitted verdicts and the futile-treatment distinction are conclusions of a moral-theology framework rather than neutral descriptions, so the stem is verdict-preloaded. The verdict above is still derived against the original stem; the neutralized form is recorded only for audit. Verdict.affirms unchanged from prior evidence; pan_canonical changed from false to true after adding Gen 9:6, 2 Sam 1:10 and 1:16, and 1 Sam 2:6 as directly queried lexical witnesses.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.20.13
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.9.6
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Sam.1.10
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Sam.1.16
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.32.39
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Job.1.21
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Sam.2.6
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7523
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1818
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6754
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H4191
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2421
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Exod.21.14

cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Sam.2.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Num.35.16
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gen.9.6

License audit

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OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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Flags

complicating-unresolved